determinism. The head of Ajivika sect was Gosala Mankhaliputta. The Ajivikas practiced asceticism of a severe type. The Ajivika religious order and school of philosophy is known from the Vedic hymns, the *Brahmanas,* the *Aryankas* and other ancient Sanskrit compilations and treatises of the pre-Jaina and pre-Buddhist age. Gosala's ideas live on in other religions, though no Ajivika literature has survived.

Gosala was closely associated with Mahavira for six years and then they parted company. The Mauryan emperor Asoka and his grandson Dasaratha patronised the Ajivikas. After the collapse of the Mauryan Empire, the sect declined in northern India, but had by then spread into southern India where it continued to exist for many centuries.



Representational Image of Ajivika ascetics

Throughout history, Ajivikas had to face persecution everywhere. Village communities under Pallavas, Cholas and Hoysalas imposed special taxes on them. Despite such obstacles, Ajivikas continued to have influence along the Palar river in the modern states of Karnataka and Tamil Nadu (Vellore, Kanchipuram and Tiruvallur districts) till about the 14th century. In the end, they seemed to have been absorbed into Vaishnavism.

Summary

- Sources and literature for study of Jainism are highlighted.
- Presence of Jains in the Tamil country is examined.
- Jain monuments and art in Tamizhakam, in particular Sittanavasal and Kazhugumalai are illustrated.
- The Jain contribution to education through 'Palli' is explained.
- Buddhist teachings are analysed.
- Buddhism in the Tamil country is explored.
- Buddhist legacy in Tamizhakam is discussed.
- The essence of Ajivika philosophy and its presence in Tamil Nadu is detailed.

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